

DECORY EDWARDS

Research Statement

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Research program

My research began in heterogeneous-agent macroeconomics, household finance, and wealth inequality. My dissertation's first chapter develops and estimates a life-cycle model in which households earn different returns on assets, then studies the implications for wealth accumulation and tax policy. The second uses Health and Retirement Study data to examine how interpersonal trust relates to returns to net wealth. The third develops a decision-theoretic measure of wealth inequality aversion and applies it to Survey of Consumer Finances data. Together, these projects study how differences in households' opportunities, information, relationships, and financial returns generate unequal economic outcomes.

Building on this foundation, I am developing an applied policy agenda centered on education, energy, and health. These fields determine access to human capital, essential services, and protection from financial risk. Across them, I combine economic theory with panel methods, natural experiments, difference-in-differences, event studies, instrumental variables, and structural modeling. My objective is to identify not only whether a policy changes an average outcome, but also how its benefits, costs, and risks are distributed across households and communities.

Education policy: developing research agenda

My first new research priority is education policy. I am developing a program on charter schools and student opportunity in Houston and Texas, with particular interest in school access, academic outcomes, institutional expansion, and heterogeneous effects across neighborhoods and student groups. Texas offers a useful setting because charter and traditional public schools operate within the same regional labor and housing markets while differing in governance, enrollment, and scale. The central empirical challenge is selection: families choose schools, schools differ in whom they serve, and new campuses do not open randomly. My goal is therefore to build designs around credible sources of variation, including admissions lotteries where available, openings and closures, phased expansion, geographic access, and policy changes that alter enrollment opportunities.

I view this as a developing agenda rather than completed work. The immediate tasks are to identify questions for which institutional detail and available data support a defensible counterfactual, construct reproducible school-by-year and student-level files where access permits, and distinguish a focused academic contribution from broader descriptive consulting reports. The longer-run agenda would connect school choice to outcomes beyond test scores, including course progression, college readiness, teacher labor markets, and the distribution of access across Houston communities. My work as a private tutor and my growing classroom exposure motivate the questions, but the research itself will be disciplined by identification, transparent measurement, and careful treatment of competing explanations.

Energy policy and market institutions

My energy-policy work combines an earlier macroeconomic interest in climate and production with new empirical analysis of Texas electricity markets. At the Federal Reserve Board, I replicated and extended a dynamic general-equilibrium model in which fossil-fuel use creates a climate externality. That work required deriving equilibrium conditions, constructing the steady state, implementing the model in Dynare, and validating the quantitative results. It taught me how energy constraints can be embedded in a model of aggregate behavior and how policy conclusions depend on assumptions about technology, prices, and adjustment.

More recently, I have produced a set of applied reports using public data on ERCOT and the Texas retail electricity market. One study uses difference-in-differences and event-study designs to examine changes in generator reliability and retail prices following Texas weatherization policy. A second uses wholesale cost shifters as instruments to study retail electricity demand and cost pass-through. Additional reports evaluate the consumer harm associated with prolonged outages after Hurricane Beryl and the competitive implications of generation ownership concentration. These are applied policy reports rather than completed journal articles, but they establish a foundation for an academic agenda on reliability regulation, market power, household exposure to outages, and the distributional consequences of electricity pricing.

The next step is to integrate these questions more directly with household behavior. Reliability failures and price spikes are aggregate shocks, but their welfare effects depend on housing quality, access to backup resources, income, location, and the ability to shift consumption. I am interested in combining utility, weather, outage, and neighborhood data to estimate both average effects and the unequal burden of system stress. This would connect the institutional detail of electricity markets to my broader work on heterogeneity and household resilience.

Health policy, insurance, and household welfare

My health-policy interests focus on insurance access, medical spending, and the interaction between health programs and household financial security. In prior empirical work, I reproduced an analysis of the Medicare Part D rollout using Health and Retirement Study data, panel fixed effects, difference-in-differences, and event-study methods. That project gave me experience treating a policy rollout as a natural experiment, constructing longitudinal variables, assessing identifying assumptions, and testing robustness across specifications.

A recent applied report examines Texas's position as a non-expansion state during the 2023 Medicaid unwinding. Using event-study and difference-in-differences comparisons with neighboring expansion states, the analysis separates insurance coverage, health outcomes, and cost barriers to care. The broader research agenda asks when changes in public insurance translate into changes in utilization, health, debt, savings, and wealth depletion. This is a natural extension of my household-finance research: insurance policy changes exposure to risk, while household assets determine the capacity to absorb that risk.

A coherent next stage

The next stage of my research places education policy first while developing complementary projects in energy and health. Each field concerns an essential service, a mix of public and private provision, and outcomes whose average effects can conceal large distributional differences. I will combine structural reasoning with transparent applied econometrics, reproducible public-data workflows, and collaboration with researchers and practitioners who understand the institutions behind the data. My goal is research that contributes to academic debates while providing credible and accessible evidence for policymakers, schools, health systems, regulators, and communities.